operational. I didn't know why the Longhorn was required for him instead of the Rover, but I wasn't about to ask and irritate him even more.

Especially since the experience had been bonding. Thereafter he and I were mates.

His call sign was Magic.

I'd often pass an entire night chatting to Magic. He and his crew liked to talk, to laugh, eat. (I dimly recall them feasting one night on fresh crabs.) Above all they loved practical jokes. After one sortie, Magic zoomed out his camera, told me to look. I leaned into my screen. From twenty thousand feet his view of the curvature of Earth was astonishing.

Slowly, he turned his camera.

My screen filled with breasts.

Porn magazine.

Ah, you got me, Magic.

Some pilots were women. Exchanges with them went very differently. One night I found myself speaking to a British pilot who mentioned how gorgeous the moon was.

It's full, she said. *You should see it, Widow Six Seven.*

I see it. Through one of the holes in my wall. Lovely.

Suddenly the radio burst to life: a shrill chorus. The guys back at Dwyer told us to "get a room." I felt myself blushing. I hoped the pilot hadn't thought I was flirting. I hoped she wouldn't think so now. Above all, I hoped she, and all other pilots, wouldn't work out who I was, and tell the British press that I was using the war as a way to meet women. I hoped the press wouldn't then treat her as they'd treated every other girl I'd ever had anything to do with.

Before that shift ended, however, the pilot and I overcame this brief awkwardness and did some solid work together. She helped me monitor a Taliban bunker, right in the heart of no-man's-land, not far beyond Delhi's walls. There were thermals around the bunker…human forms. A dozen, I guessed. Maybe fifteen.

Taliban, for sure, we said. Who else would be moving in those trenches?